

Sake Makers Hope for UNESCO Listing

The Japanese rice wine called sake is made using ancient brewing methods. They date back more than a thousand years.

Junichiro Ozawa, the 18th-generation leader of Ozawa Brewery, founded in 1702, hopes sake-brewing will win recognition as a UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage. Officials of the UN agency are expected to decide on the nomination next month.

“We always think about the people who’re enjoying our sake when we make it. I’m now so excited, imagining the faces of all the people around the world,” he told reporters during a visit to the brewery on the edge of Tokyo.

Sake was the drink of choice of the nobility represented in Japan’s most celebrated work of writing, *The Tale of Genji*. Sake has been growing in popularity in recent years, helped by an increasing international interest in Japanese cooking and food.

Nami Goto, managing director of Research and Development for the Brewing Society of Japan, speaks during a media tour at Ozawa Sake Brewery in Ome, on the western outskirts of Tokyo, Japan, Wednesday, Nov. 13, 2024. (AP Photo/Hiro Komae)

Sake exports from Japan total more than \$265 million a year, with the U.S. and China as the two biggest buyers. That information comes from the Japan Sake and Shochu Makers Association.

Sake exports have almost doubled in value since 2018. But exports still make up a very small amount of overall sake production in Japan. Brazil, Mexico and Southeast Asia, as well as France and the rest of Europe, all places where Japanese restaurants are gaining popularity, are starting to take a liking to sake.

The main elements in sake are rice and water. The production process takes about two months and includes fermentation and pressing.

For a product to be named Japanese sake, the rice must be Japanese. The relatively soft quality of freshwater in Japan, like that provided by the two wells at Ozawa Brewery, is also important.

Among Ozawa’s sake choices is the Junmai Daiginjo, one of the top offerings, with 15 percent alcohol content and costing about \$23 for 720 milliliters.

Another, Karakuti Nigorizake, is unrefined sake. The liquid is not as clear as usual sake. It has 17 percent alcohol content and sells for \$16 for 1,800 milliliters.

This photo shows Ozawa Sake Brewery, who makes "Sawanoi," a Japanese sake brand, in Ome, on the western outskirts of Tokyo, Japan, Wednesday, Nov. 13, 2024. (AP Photo/Hiro Komae)

In Japan, sake is used to purify and to celebrate. Small tastes of sake from a cup show the confirmation of a marriage, for example.

“Sake is not just an alcoholic beverage. It is Japanese culture itself,” said Hitoshi Utsunomiya of the Japan Sake and Shochu Makers Association.

The UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage designation can be awarded to practices passed down for generations. These practices include spoken traditions, performing arts, and food making.

The UNESCO designation is not meant to be used for commercial purposes. But industry officials are open about their hope that such recognition will increase international sales. They believe the designation could help the tradition stay alive amid competition from beer, grape-based wine and other drinks.

One reason for sake’s growing popularity around the world is that its smooth flavor goes well with a number of foods. These foods include sushi, spicy Asian and Western dishes, says Max Del Vita, a sake wine expert and co-founder of The Sake Company, an import and distribution business in Singapore.

Del Vita told The Associated Press. “Sake is more than a drink. It is a living embodiment of Japan’s seasonal rhythms, community values and artistic heritage.”

I’m John Russell.

Yuri Kageyama reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

brew - v. ต้มหรือหมัก (สาเก เบียร์ ฯลฯ)

fermentation - n. กระบวนการสลายสารประกอบที่ให้พลังงาน (เช่น คาร์โบไฮเดรตเป็น คาร์บอนไดออกไซด์และแอลกอฮอล์) โดยจุลินทรีย์ (เช่น แบคทีเรียหรือยีสต์)

beverage - n. เครื่องดื่ม

designation - n. การแต่งตั้ง ชื่อเรียก หรือตำแหน่งที่โดดเด่น

practice - n. ขนบธรรมเนียม การกระทำที่ทำซ้ำๆ หรือเป็นประจำ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is stated about the production of sake in the initial paragraphs?

- A. It involves modern, innovative brewing techniques.
- B. Its brewing methods are relatively new, developed a few centuries ago.
- C. It is created using ancient brewing methods that are over a thousand years old.
- D. It is primarily made through fermentation without any brewing.

2. What is Junichiro Ozawa's primary goal for sake-brewing?

- A. To expand Ozawa Brewery's international sales significantly.
- B. To modernize the ancient brewing methods of sake.
- C. To achieve UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage recognition for sake-brewing.
- D. To introduce new types of sake with different alcohol contents.

3. What feeling did Junichiro Ozawa express regarding the global enjoyment of their sake?

- A. Concern about potential competition.
- B. Disinterest in international markets.
- C. Excitement about people worldwide enjoying their sake.
- D. Regret about the slow pace of recognition.

4. According to the article, what is one reason for sake's growing popularity in recent years?

- A. A decline in the popularity of other alcoholic beverages.
- B. Its exclusive availability only to Japanese nobility.
- C. An increasing international interest in Japanese cooking and food.
- D. Its newly developed modern brewing techniques.

5. Who is Nami Goto, as mentioned in the article?

- A. The current leader of Ozawa Brewery.
- B. A UNESCO official involved in the nomination decision.
- C. A managing director for Research and Development for the Brewing Society of Japan.
- D. A reporter covering the media tour.

6. What is the annual total value of sake exports from Japan, and which two countries are the biggest buyers?

- A. Less than \$200 million; Brazil and Mexico.
- B. More than \$265 million; the U.S. and China.
- C. Approximately \$100 million; France and other European countries.
- D. Over \$500 million; Southeast Asia and Europe.

7. Despite the increase in value, what is stated about sake exports relative to overall sake production in Japan?

- A. They now account for the majority of sake production.
- B. They have decreased significantly since 2018.
- C. They still constitute a very small amount of overall sake production.
- D. They have remained stagnant since 2018.

8. Which regions, besides the U.S. and China, are noted for starting to develop an interest in sake?

- A. Only France and some parts of Europe.
- B. Brazil, Mexico, Southeast Asia, France, and the rest of Europe.
- C. Primarily African and Middle Eastern countries.
- D. Japan's neighboring countries exclusively.

9. What are the primary ingredients of sake and how long does its production process typically take?

- A. Barley and hops; several weeks.
- B. Rice and water; about two months.
- C. Grapes and yeast; a few days.
- D. Wheat and sugar; less than a month.

10. What two essential criteria must be met for a product to be officially named 'Japanese sake'?

- A. It must be brewed for at least three months and contain 15% alcohol.
- B. The rice used must be Japanese, and the freshwater must be of a relatively soft quality.
- C. It must be produced only at the Ozawa Brewery and sold internationally.
- D. It needs to be certified by the UN agency and exported to the U.S. and China.

11. How does Karakuti Nigorizake differ from Junmai Daiginjo, according to the article?

- A. Karakuti Nigorizake is more expensive per milliliter and has a lower alcohol content.
- B. Karakuti Nigorizake is unrefined, less clear, has higher alcohol, and offers a larger volume for less cost.
- C. Junmai Daiginjo is unrefined, while Karakuti Nigorizake is a top offering.
- D. They have the same alcohol content but vastly different prices.

12. What cultural roles does sake play in Japan, as mentioned in the article?

- A. It is exclusively for daily consumption.

- B. It is used for purification and celebration, such as confirming a marriage.
- C. It is only consumed by the nobility.
- D. Its use is limited to religious ceremonies.

13. How did Hitoshi Utsunomiya of the Japan Sake and Shochu Makers Association describe sake?

- A. Primarily as a commercial product for export.
- B. As a simple alcoholic drink with no deeper meaning.
- C. As Japanese culture itself, beyond just being an alcoholic beverage.
- D. As a historical relic of the past, with declining relevance.

14. What is the official stated purpose of the UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage designation, and what additional hope do industry officials have for it?

- A. To strictly prohibit any commercial use of the designated practices.
- B. To promote tourism to Japan, specifically to sake breweries.
- C. To recognize generational practices like food making, with officials also hoping it boosts international sales and helps the tradition survive.
- D. To create a new international standard for alcoholic beverage production.

15. According to Max Del Vita, what is a key factor contributing to sake's global popularity, and how does he further characterize sake?

- A. Its high alcohol content, making it a strong alternative to spirits.
- B. Its smooth flavor that pairs well with various foods, and he describes it as a living embodiment of Japanese culture.
- C. Its affordability compared to other international beverages.
- D. Its exclusive use in traditional Japanese ceremonies.